

Storming of Bastille Prison

Conditions of Peasantry

The peasantry made up the bulk of French society. The peasants were serfs. They had to work certain days in the week for their lords without any remuneration. They could not marry or dispose of their lands without the lord's permission. Lords claimed certain feudal dues such as the right to levy fees even for using ovens to bake bread, and a toll on sheep and cattle possessed by the peasants. It has been estimated that the peasant paid eighty percent of his earnings to various tax collectors. Carlyle wrote that 'one third of them had nothing but third-rate potatoes to eat for one-third of the year.'

Three Estates

French society had three main divisions or *estates*: Clergy (the priestly class), Nobility (the landed and aristocratic class), and the rest, the commoners, formed the unprivileged class. The clergy and the nobility enjoyed special privileges and they were exempted from various taxes imposed by the monarchy. Out of the three divisions, only the third estate bore the brunt of taxation, as other two estates were exempted from tax payment due to the special privileges. The important taxes were *tithe*, a tax exclusively collected by the church on the laity, *Taille*, a tax paid by the peasants, *gabelle* salt tax, and tax on tobacco.

The peasants could not fight feudal regulations on their own. They looked for outside help and leadership. The rising bourgeoisie wanted their political power to match their economic status. They wanted to have a voice in government. So the bourgeoisie took the lead and were instrumental in bringing about the French Revolution.

The Bourgeoisie comprised the educated middle class. Writers, doctors, teachers, lawyers, judges, and civil servants formed this class.

Financial Bankruptcy

France was in constant war with neighbouring British Empire that proved to be too costly for the exchequer. It had spent enormous sums on the Seven Years' War with Britain and Prussia, and more again during the American war with Britain. The valuable assistance which the French gave to the American colonists was such as it could not really afford. The government had to pay high interests on the loan. In order to settles the dues, the government imposed more taxes on the common people. The nobles and higher clergy hesitated to come forward and save the state by voluntarily giving up their claims to exemption from taxes. Matters were further complicated by the extravagance of the court and the incompetence of the Louis XVI.

Role of Intellectuals

Long before the revolution of 1789 there was a revolution in the realm of ideas. Public intellectuals (who were called *philosophes* in the French language) who were inspired by the Enlightenment ideal of applying reason to all spheres of knowledge played a key role in preparing the soil for the outbreak of the French Revolution. The writings of Voltaire and Rousseau acted as an impetus to the revolution. Montesquieu (1689–1755), in his *The Spirit of Laws*, argued for the division of power among the legislative, executive and judiciary and opposed the concentration of power in a single hand. Voltaire (1694–1778), in his *The Age of Louis XIV*, opposed the religious superstitions of the French and criticised the French administration

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